



K. M. KISHAN

Fractured Relations

PATNA Coalition politics is not without unpleasant pitfalls—one that often leaves the ruling members with a broken heart. Senior BJP MLA in Bihar, Phaluguni Yadav, is one such disillusioned soul who has threatened self-immolation if Chief Minister Nitish Kumar fails to dismiss Food and

Consumer Protection Minister Narendra Singh. Singh and his MLA son had allegedly thrown Yadav off the dais at a public rally in Jamui district on May 28. It left him with a fractured ankle. The scuffle broke out when Yadav tried to grab credit for the construction of a bridge.

New Role

PATNA The Bihar Government has taken a cue from the Mughal era when eunuchs used to guard palaces and were the eyes and ears of emperors. The Government intends to post the third gender as security guards in girls' hostels, colleges and hospitals. "We are in the final stage of an action plan conscientiously made to ensure rehabilitation of the much-maligned tribe," says Vijay Prakash, state social welfare principal secretary. "Almost one per cent of the state's population could be such individuals, although many of them may have concealed their true identity," he told INDIA TODAY.

In 2006, Patna



AJAY KUMAR

Municipal Corporation had used eunuchs as tax collectors. The drive brought in large collections to the cash-strapped civic body. Recalcitrant tax evaders preferred to pay up rather than being serenaded by singing and dancing eunuchs.

The Social Welfare Department now wants to expand the margins of its rehabilitation net for the eunuchs. "We will give

ANGUISHED: Yadav

More than a fortnight later—when Yadav's cries for action against Singh and his son fell on deaf ears—the angry and anguished MLA submitted his resignation to his state party chief. He claims, "If coalition dharma demands public humiliation by a senior partner, I am not ready for it."

There are speculations that the BJP wishes to settle the issue amicably. For the record, Nitish—who is said to be Singh's friend—has said that leaders of both the parties will resolve the issue. The four-time saffron MLA, however, is unwilling to forget and forgive. Meanwhile, the police have taken cognisance of his complaint and have registered an FIR against the minister.

by Amitabh Srivastava

All in the Family

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Marriages are made in heaven, but in an extraordinary matrimony, a retired government official had the rare privilege of having his second wedding solemnised by his son.

On June 14, 64-year-old Kannampuzha Antony's wedding rites



A. S. SATHEESH

(L-R) Antony, Brigitte, Antri were performed by his son, Father Antri Kannampuzha, a priest. Antony had been staying alone as his working children were away. "Solitude in old age is worse than jail," says Antony.

At the ceremony in St Sebastian's Catholic Church in Valappad near Trissur, Father Antri customarily issued his father and new step-mother Brigitte all the sacramental instructions for the new couple in order to lead a happy and contented married life.

Antony's wedding was attended by his two daughters-in-law (his other two sons were away), grandchildren, sisters and brothers. "My sons and daughters-in-law persuaded me to marry again as my first wife Reetha died seven years ago," said Antony. Ironically, the father addressed his son as "Father" while the vows were being exchanged at the altar.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

GENDER BENDER: Eunuchs will have jobs as guards

them proper training and deploy them as paid activists to spread awareness about women empowerment and children's health issues in the backwaters," says Prakash. Authorities believe that the eunuch's inputs will not be coloured since they have no personal axe to grind.

by Amitabh Srivastava